

Introduction

Facebook has grown phenomenally over the past several years from an Ivy League social web application to one of the top ten most visited web sites on the internet. It currently has more than 250 million active users and more than 350,000 active applications with billions of page views per month.

It comes with its own platform for application development which consists of an HTML-based markup language called Facebook Markup Language (FBML), an application programming interface (API) for making representational state transfer (REST) calls to Facebook, a SQL-styled query language for interacting with Facebook called Facebook Query Language (FQL), a scripting language called Facebook JavaScript for enriching the user experience, and a set of client programming libraries. Facebook applications are hosted on the application developer's own server, but because of the way they interface with Facebook, they appear to users to be part of Facebook itself. Using Facebook applications, developers can add custom features and new ways for users to interact with each other using Facebook.

We'll help you get started on building powerful Facebook applications, and details how to use the core technologies of the Facebook Platform to create an application, how to deploy, monitor, and tune it, how to work with data stored in Facebook, including photos, how to handle multimedia and other custom data within Facebook applications, how to send notifications and invitations from within an application, update a user's profile, how to create application control panels for users, and much more.

Hopefully, this book will go a long way into making you understand what makes applications work on Facebook, how to monitor their progress, and make changes that maximise their potential for success. This book will not only act as a reference for the various parts of the Facebook Platform, but also address the entire process of creating applications from inception to deployment and beyond. Besides taking you through the necessary steps to getting your application built in the